Hulagu's death had given the Chagatai armies an edge, and right before Ghazan's khanship began, Chagatai soldiers had finally driven the Il-khanates out.[8]

Now Duwa had a base from which he could do more than raid north Indian lands; he could actually plan a conquest.

In the second year of 'Ala'-ud-Din's reign, the Mongols crossed through the mountains and came into the north. The sultan sent his brother Ulugh and his close friend Zafar at the head of a large Delhi army to meet them. At Jalandhar, the Delhi army won an easy victory over the Mongols: "Many were slain or taken prisoners," says Barani, "and many heads were sent to Delhi. The victory . . . greatly strengthened the authority of 'Alau-d din."[9]

In the flush of victory, the sultan sent an invasion force of his own westward, against the Hindu state of Gujarat. It fell easily and was folded into the Delhi sultanate. Among the prisoners taken captive was a eunuch named Malik Kafur; when 'Ala'-ud-Din saw him, he was "captivated" by the slave's beauty. From that time on, Malik Kafur was his constant companion.[10]

He intended to keep up the war against the Hindu states, but the Mongols now returned. Having tested the enemy's strength, the Chagatai khan Duwa was ready to embark on a full-scale conquest. In 1299, he sent a force magnitudes larger than that of the 1296 invasion—two hundred thousand horsemen, according to contemporary reports—under the command of his son. Instead of raiding and fighting against border fortresses, this army ignored every target between the mountains and Delhi, and made straight for the capital city.[11]

Panic swept across the north. Villagers in the Mongol path abandoned their houses and farms and fled to Delhi, only to find that the city was in poor shape to receive them.

> The old fortifications had not been kept in repair, and terror prevailed, such as never before had been seen or heard of. All men, great and small, were in dismay. Such a concourse had crowded into the city that the streets and markets and mosques could not contain them. Everything became very dear. The roads were stopped against caravans and merchants, and distress fell upon the people.[12]

'Ala'-ud-Din summoned governors and their armies from all over his sultanate to report to Delhi for its defense. But, given the state of the city and the panic inside its gates, he ignored the advice of his councillors to prepare for siege and marched out of Delhi, towards a pitched battle on open ground.

The battle lines between the two massive armies stretched on for miles.